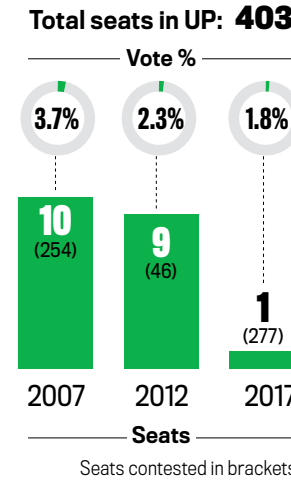


BOTTOMED OUT

The RLD always had limited influence but even that seemed all but lost by 2017



RLD'S SUPPORT TO THE FARMERS' AGITATION HAS GOT THE JATS BACK IN THEIR CORNER AGAIN

the alliance promises to be a win-win for both sides. "The RLD has a strong presence at the block level in the region, especially among the Jats. They had a huge role during the farmers' protests in western UP. Another reason we tied up with the RLD is that both Akhilesh Yadav and Jayant Chaudhary have a huge appeal among the youth. The combination will definitely benefit us."

Jat-Muslim unity

The RLD's fall from regional pre-eminence started after the Muzaffarnagar Hindu-Muslim riots in August-September 2013 which left 62 people dead. A major section of the local Jats shifted their loyalty to the BJP. Last year, the RLD started an outreach campaign, 'Bhaichara Zindabad', to reunite the Jat community with other sections in western UP, mainly the Muslims and Dalits. The campaign started from Muzaffarnagar, the epicentre of the riots, in October and has become a socio-cultural platform to perform poetry, theatre and initiate discussions on several topics. A primary motive is also to restore the bond between the Jats, who command a social dominance way above their population (almost 15 per cent) in western UP, and Muslims (22 per cent).

As a senior RLD leader put it, "If we succeed in uniting the Jats and Muslims, we will be unstoppable because the combination of Jats, Muslims, Yadavs and a few OBC castes will take our voteshare well above 40 per cent, enough to defeat the BJP." Though the farm laws have been repealed, the farmers are still agitated over MSP, payment dues of sugarcane growers and several other factors which could make the RLD-SP alliance their first choice against the BJP.

Of late, the RLD has also inducted several Muslim leaders including Noman Masood (brother of ex-Congress MLA Imran Masood), senior BSP leader Haji Yunus and veteran journalist Shahid Siddiqui. It also has a Dalit wing to look into the needs of a community that makes up 20 per cent of voters in western UP. 'Team RLD' convenor Anupam Mishra says, "It's a do-or-die election for us. This is the RLD's first election under Jayant's leadership. We are seeing huge turnouts at our rallies and several leaders from other parties, including the BSP, BJP and Congress, are joining us. A separate 'Team RLD' has been formed to get professionals to join the party and we are seeing a good response there too. So it seems like we are the first choice in western UP in the coming election."

RLD leaders are so positive they are hoping for a deputy chief ministership for Jayant if the party comes to power with the SP. Uttar Pradesh-based political analyst Dr Shilp Shikha Singh says, "The alliance has made the BJP very nervous in west UP. The *kisan andolan* didn't just revive the RLD's fortunes, it gave a new persona to Jayant's leadership." The state will know in March if that persona has translated into votes. ■